Iterative Prompt Development

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Core Idea

The first prompt you write will rarely be perfect - and that's fine. What matters is having a **good iterative process** to refine prompts until they work well for your specific application.

"There probably isn't a perfect prompt for everything under the sun, it's more important that you have a process for developing a good prompt for your specific application."

The Iterative Prompting Loop

Similar to the machine learning development cycle:

1. **Have an idea** for the task you want to complete
2. **Write a first prompt** - clear, specific, and give the model time to think
3. **Run it and evaluate** the output
4. **Identify what's wrong** - unclear instructions? Not enough reasoning space?
5. **Refine the prompt** and repeat

Worked Example: Chair Fact Sheet → Product Description

Each iteration added a new layer of refinement:

Iteration	Change Made	Result
1	Basic prompt: write a product description from a fact sheet	Output was too long
2	Added: "use at most 50 words"	Much shorter, but LLMs are imprecise with exact word counts
3	Tried: "use at most 3 sentences" or "280 characters"	Alternative ways to control length
4	Added: description is for furniture retailers, focus on technical details and materials	More technical, trade-focused output
5	Added: include every 7-character product ID	Product IDs included at the end
6	Added: include a dimensions table and format as HTML	Full HTML page with table rendered correctly

Key Takeaways:

- **No one writes the perfect prompt on the first try,** even experienced practitioners iterate
- "30 perfect prompts" articles on the internet miss the point, context-specific prompts matter more
- Keep best practices in mind from the start (clear + specific, give time to think), then iterate from there
- For **early-stage apps**: developing with one example is fine
- For **mature apps**: test prompts against 10–100 examples to measure average and worst-case performance

Prompt guidelines

- Be clear and specific
- Analyze why result does not give desired output.
- Refine the idea and the prompt
- Repeat

Iterative Process

- Try something
- Analyze where the result does not give what you want
- Clarify instructions, give more time to think
- Refine prompts with a batch of examples